Death & the King's Horseman: Plot Summary

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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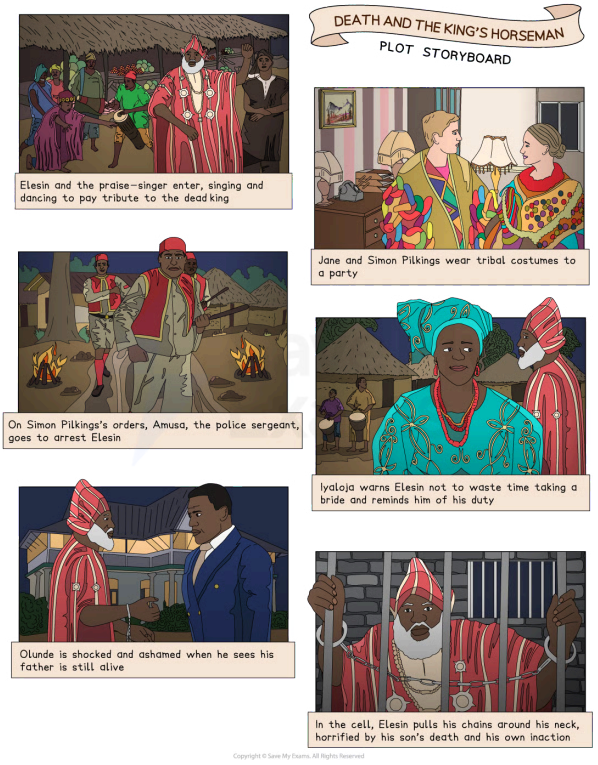
Plot Summary

One of the most important things you can do in preparation for the exam is to "know" the plot of Death and the King's Horseman thoroughly. Once you know the play well, you should be comfortable and familiar with key events that you can then link to larger ideas. Having an in-depth knowledge and understanding of the text will help you to gain confidence to find the most relevant references to support your response.

Plot storyboard



Plot storyboard

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

Help me understand

The play opens in a Nigerian marketplace in 1943 during **World War II**. Elesin Oba (the king's horseman) must complete an important cultural **ritual**. According to tradition, Elesin must follow his king to the afterlife by committing suicide. This ritual is important to the community as, according to **Yoruba** beliefs, it prevents their community from disappearing into an abyss or void.

The praise-singer is doubtful about Elesin's intentions as he loves life so much. The women dance with Elesin and chant to celebrate his **impending** death. Elesin asks to wed a young woman. Iyaloja (the girl's future mother-in-law) attempts to convince Elesin against this but eventually gives in so as to not disturb the order of the world.

Meanwhile, in a large house, Simon Pilkings, the British **district officer**, and his wife, Jane, prepare for a costume party and are dressed in **egungun** costumes (usually worn in honour of tribal **ancestors**). The police sergeant Amusa arrives to tell Simon Pilkings about Elesin's plans to "commit death". He leaves, shocked at the Pilkings' disrespect for African customs.

Simon tells his servant to ask Amusa to arrest Elesin. In the marketplace, Amusa and his constables try to get through a group of women who halt his progress and insult them for working for the English. Later, Elesin steps out of the stall the women were protecting and explains that his bride will now bear a child. He dances to the drums and under the praise-singer's guidance, sinks into a trance-like state and prepares for death.

Olunde, Elesin's son, arrives at the Pilkings' party. Their discussion becomes heated, especially when Olunde says that news of the king's death brought him home to honour his father's death. Elesin enters stage, handcuffed, and Olunde expresses his anger at his father's inability to carry out his duty.

Locked in a cell, Elesin explains to Simon that disorder will result from his interference. A furious Iyaloja visits Elesin and criticises his dishonourable behaviour. A group of women enter with a large object covered with cloth and reveal Olunde's body. In response, Elesin pulls his chains tightly around his neck and strangles himself. Simon tries to resuscitate him, but Iyaloja tells him he must accept the consequences for disrespecting the Yoruba customs.

Elesin's bride closes his eyes and pours dirt over them, and Iyaloja leads her off stage, talking of her unborn child.

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Knowing the plot of the play very well is important, but it is equally important that you pay attention to the stage directions Soyinka uses to convey the dramatic developments of the story. These give extra information

Act-By-Act Plot Summary

Act I

- The play opens in a Nigerian marketplace where Elesin, the king's horseman, enters with drummers and a praise-singer as the market closes for the day
- Elesin rushes to the women in the marketplace, eager for their attention, but the praise-singer warns him about earthly joys and reminds him of his duty:
  - He must prepare to die in honour of the king, an important ancient custom
- Elesin enjoys being dressed in fine clothes and praised by the women in the market
- He then sees a young woman and reminds the praise-singer that, as the king's horseman, he is entitled to any woman:
  - Iyaloja speaks against this and says the woman Elesin desires is about to be married to her son but, believing she cannot deny his last wish, finally agrees
- The women fetch the girl and Elesin prepares for his wedding

Act 2

- The act opens in the home of the British district officer, Simon Pilkings:
  - Such officers would act as **magistrates** and supervisors over a district in the **colonies** on behalf of the **British Empire**
- Simon Pilkings and his wife, Jane, dance through the living room in egungun costumes
- A policeman, Amusa, arrives and expresses shock at the costumes
- After Amusa leaves in disgust, Simon tells Jane the note says that Elesin plans to "commit death" according to native custom
- Simon calls for Joseph, the servant, who explains that the ritual suicide Elesin must undertake is an important custom in the community:
  - He explains that as the king died one month ago tonight, Elesin, as his horseman, must follow him to the afterlife
- Simon is exasperated; he remembers Elesin causing issues previously:
  - He relates how he helped Elesin's son, Olunde, go to medical school in England
- Simon instructs Joseph to speak with Amusa and ensure they arrest Elesin
- Jane wants to change out of the costumes and forget about the party but Simon tells her that the British prince is attending the party and they must see him
- Jane forgets any previous concerns and exclaims that, luckily, with her costume, she won't need gloves

Amusa and two constables attempt to get through a group of women
- The women mock Amusa for his **subservience** to the white man and say he is excluded from the market:
  - They grab the constables' hats and batons and pretend to be at a party
  - As they mimic English voices, they praise Amusa for his loyalty

- The constables eventually retreat
- Elesin enters the marketplace, stepping out from a stall with a white velvet cloth:
  - He says he has taken his bride's virginity and she will bear him a child

- Elesin hears the drums, dances, and goes into a trance-like state and the praise-singer helps him prepare for death

Act 4

- The act opens at the Pilkings' home, where residents dance to a poorly-performed **waltz**:
  - The prince arrives and the band play "**Rule Britannia**"
  - Simon demonstrates a native dance but is interrupted by a resident with a note

- Upon reading the note from Amusa, the resident and Simon discuss whether to tell the prince as the colony is meant to be "safe and secure"
- Simon decides to take matters into his own hands
- When Simon leaves, Jane recognises Olunde, Elesin's son, who is home from England:
  - They discuss the war in Europe and the reason for Olunde's return:
    - He says he is here to honour his father's sacrifice
    - Olunde tells Jane he must see Simon and stop his interference in his father's ritual

- The drumming outside stops and Olunde, sure the ritual is done, goes to find his father
- Elesin enters stage, having broken free from the constables
- He sees Olunde and falls to the ground but Olunde calls Elesin an "eater of leftovers" and walks off in disgust

Act 5

- The act opens in Simon's study, where Elesin is chained inside a cell
- Simon enters and Elesin rages at him for taking away his son, as well as his destiny
- Iyaloja arrives to visit Elesin and admonishes his weak will
- She asks Simon to let Elesin take part in releasing their king and a group of women enter, chanting and carrying a cloth-wrapped object
- Iyaloja moves the cloth and reveals Olunde's body as the praise-singer speaks of the destruction of order
- At this, Elesin pulls the chains around his neck and strangles himself
- Simon attempts to save his life but Iyaloja stops him, telling him he must accept his responsibility for Olunde's death

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